

THE ONES WHO STAY

Nobody warns you about the quiet parts.

The industry loves to talk about the noise—the screaming, the heat, the chaos, the adrenaline. That's the sexy stuff. That's what makes it onto Netflix and into the fantasies of people who think "chef" means white coat and tasting spoons and someone filming you being dramatic about a soufflé.

But no one tells you about 11:47pm on a Tuesday, sitting on an upturned milk crate in the alley, knees screaming, feet numb, watching steam rise off your own forearms because you've been standing over heat so long your body doesn't know how to cool down anymore.

That's the part that decides who stays.

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The first time I properly understood kitchen humour, I thought I was witnessing a crime.

It was maybe three months in. I'd graduated from "liability" to "tolerable"—which, in kitchen terms, is basically a promotion. Still at the bottom of the ladder, but at least no one actively flinched when I walked past the pass.

We'd had a brutal Friday. One of those nights where the rail never emptied and every docket seemed to come with a modification designed by someone who hated joy. Dairy-free but with butter. Medium rare but not pink. "Chef's choice" followed by a list of seventeen things they didn't want.

Somewhere around the two-hundredth cover, one of the senior chefs—a guy named Marco who'd been on grill for six years and had forearms like industrial cables—cut himself.

Not badly. Just a slip. The kind of nick you'd bandage at home and complain about for three days. In the kitchen, he didn't even look down.

Just grabbed a blue bandage from the kit, wrapped it tight with his teeth holding one end, and kept flipping steaks.

Blood was already seeping through by the time plates went up.

And the first thing—the first thing—anyone said was the guy on fish, without looking up from his pan:

"Finally. Some actual fucking flavour from your section."

The whole line laughed.

Marco included.

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The best chefs I've ever worked with were also the meanest.

Not cruel. Mean. There's a difference.

Cruel people want to hurt you. Mean people want to sharpen you.

They'll call you an idiot for leaving your tongs in the wrong spot. They'll mock your knife work in front of the entire brigade. They'll ask, loudly, if you learned to season food in a hospital cafeteria.

And then, at the end of service, they'll stay an extra hour to show you how to break down a fish properly because they noticed you were struggling earlier and didn't say anything.

They won't tell you they're helping. They'll just be there, beside you, hands moving, voice low, explaining things they could easily leave you to figure out yourself.

"You're cutting against the grain. Feel that? That's wrong. Go with it. Slower. There."

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There was one afternoon—maybe eight months in—when Sam showed me who he actually was.

He had this way of appearing behind you at the exact moment you were about to fuck something up. Not after. During. Like he had a sixth sense for incompetence.

"What are you doing."

Not a question. A statement. A verdict.

I spent the first few months convinced he hated me. That he'd been assigned to watch the apprentice fail so he could report back with evidence of my uselessness.

Then one night, I came in wrecked.

Not physically—though that too. I'd had one of those days where everything outside the kitchen was falling apart. Relationship stuff. The kind of thing you're supposed to leave at the door but can't always manage to.

I thought I was hiding it. I wasn't.

Halfway through prep, Sam appeared at my station. Didn't say anything. Just watched me butcher a brunoise that should have been uniform and was instead looking like gravel from a construction site.

I waited for the "what are you doing."

Instead, he reached over, took the knife from my hand, and said:

"Go smoke. Five minutes. I've got this."

That was it.

No follow-up. No "are you okay." No HR-mandated check-in about my emotional wellbeing.

Just: go, I've got this.

When I came back, my station was immaculate. Brunoise done. Mise reset. Like nothing had happened.

He never mentioned it again.

Neither did I.

But I'd take a bullet for that man.

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That's the thing about kitchen loyalty.

It doesn't look like anything you'd recognise from normal life.

It's not hugs and heart-to-hearts and supportive text messages. It's not team-building exercises and trust falls and someone asking how your weekend was.

It's actions.

The dishie who sees you drowning and quietly starts running your pans back faster without being asked.

The guy on fish who calls his timings thirty seconds early because he clocked that you're behind and doesn't want Chef to notice.

The pastry chef who hates everyone and everything but somehow always has a spoon of something sweet waiting for you at the end of a shit service because she knows you skipped lunch and dinner and possibly breakfast too.

The head chef who screams at you for twenty minutes over a mistake that cost the restaurant twelve dollars, and then quietly takes the next major bollocking from the owner himself so it doesn't land on you.

Nobody says "I've got your back."

They just... have it.

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I think about why we stay.

The hours are inhumane. The pay is laughable. The toll on your body is permanent. Your social life dies the moment you accept your first full-time position. Relationships crumble. Sleep becomes a rumour. Your feet develop their own weather system.

And yet.

There was a night last winter—one of those marathon services where everything went right and everything hurt and by the end we were so tired we could barely speak.

I was wiping down my station. The kitchen was finally quiet. Chef was doing his walk-through, the way he always does, checking everything's locked down before we go.

He stopped at my section. Didn't say anything for a moment. Just looked at the bench, the mise containers stacked and labelled for tomorrow, the cloth folded exactly where it should be.

Then he said:

"You're starting to look like you belong here."

That was it.

He walked off. I finished wiping down. We locked up. I went home and slept like the dead.

But that sentence—six words, no fanfare, probably already forgotten by the time he said them—that's the thing I carry.

Not because it was praise.

Because it was recognition.

From someone who'd seen me fuck up a hundred times and kept me anyway. Who'd watched me burn myself, humiliate myself, send out food I should've tasted and hadn't, and still trusted me with the next service.

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At the end of every service, there's a ritual.

Someone calls time. The grill goes off. The last plates hit the pass. We wipe down stations, scrub surfaces, return the room to the pristine state it was in before we spent six hours trying to destroy it.

And then we leave.

One by one, out into the night, back to lives that feel oddly small compared to what just happened.

But before we go, there's always a moment.

A nod. A tap on the shoulder. A muttered "good service" from someone too tired to say more.

Tomorrow we'll do it again.

And again.

And again.

Because that's what we do.